

IRB INFRASTRUCTURE Established 1977

As one of the largest toll road corridor builders in the country with revenues of Rs 1,021 crore a year, the company has constructed and maintained 1,150 km of roadways

STRAIGHT AND SMOOTH

As the silver BMW rockets from rest to 100 km/h in 7.9 seconds, its driver Virendra Dattatraya Mhaikar, has to remind himself to keep an eye on the speedometer. It's easy to forget, when he's gliding down the six-lane Mumbai-Pune Expressway. And getting a ticket for speeding is the last thing that the 38-year-old chairman and managing director of IRB Infrastructure, the company that maintains the expressway, has in mind. While it's not quite the autobahn, the expressway has changed how Mumbaikars drive. The ability to go beyond 50 km/h and reach Pune in just two hours is clearly liberating. Mhaikar himself likes to be in the fast lane. "I love driving," he says.

An engineer by training, Mhaikar was inducted in the family business early. IRB was a construction company started by his father in 1977 in Mumbai. Today, the company has approximately Rs 220 crore of self-owned equipment which gives them a competitive advantage. In 1995, they bagged their first big project, the Thane-Bhiwandi bypass. In 1998, when IRB Infrastructure was incorporated, they got the build-operate-transfer rights for the Mumbai-Pune Expressway. Today, IRB is one of the largest toll road corridor builders

in the country with revenues of Rs 1,021 crore. It has built 1,150 km of road (earning revenues of Rs 2 crore a day), while 400 km is under construction. With another 430 km bagged in the last one month, the company would have built over 2,000 km of toll road by 2012.

Mhaikar has also bagged the rights to construct the Sindhudurg airport, which is being developed to provide an alternative to Goa's Dabolim airport. With the Bharuch-Pune highway, the company also has a 7.5 per cent length share of the 5,846 km Golden Quadrilateral project. And it is expanding rapidly to Himachal Pradesh, Punjab, Gujarat, and Goa.

But there are hurdles as well. Availability of manpower is clearly a big one. When he's not travelling, the young entrepreneur spends his time on what he calls "business-related activities" like researching the global infrastructure industry. He's also keen on creating environmental awareness amongst the youth.

by Nandini Valsh

5,602 km
of the 5,846-km
Golden
Quadrilateral
project,
connecting four
metros, is
four-laned.



"The rise in construction cost and the high rate of interest on term loans is a threat to India's infrastructure sector."

Virendra Mhaikar 38, Chairman

